

Japan: Rates Strategy

May Japanese pension rebalancing estimate

Our model points to a shift from equities into bonds against a backdrop of JPY weakness/equity strength, as in April. JGB index extension is estimated at +2.05 months. There appears to be a shift back toward JGBs in pension management by trust banks.

Shinichiro Kadota

+81 3 4530 1374

shinichiro.kadota2@barclays.com

BSJL, Japan

Ayao Ehara

+ 81 3 4530 1379

ayao.ehara@barclays.com

BSJL, Japan

This week: Yields down as rise in inflation risk premium takes a breather

This week saw yields fall across the curve led by the superlong sector, reversing last week's sharp rise in the inflation risk premium, with the 30y sector slightly underperforming. At the start of the week, yields fell as buybacks took the upper hand amid easing concerns around the Middle East. Thereafter, flow drove yields lower in the superlong end, especially the 40y sector, ahead of Wednesday's 40y JGB auction, which had been widely expected to clear smoothly. After the auction produced decent results, in line with our expectations, the market traded in a range, led by flow, in the absence of any major catalysts. For the week as a whole, yields ended lower across the curve.

The government plans to issue "bridging JGBs" to fund growth investment. On the 28th, the Japan Growth Strategy Headquarters compiled a proposal centered on promoting growth and crisis-management investment, stating that it is necessary to consider a policy framework under which "bridging JGBs" would secure funding over multiple fiscal years and be managed separately from the main budget. Bridging JGBs are issued on the premise that future redemption resources can be secured, and are designed to cover temporary funding shortfalls. They were previously issued to bridge the funding gap until the consumption tax hike when the government's share of the basic pension contribution was raised from one-third to one-half. However, because bridging JGBs are excluded from calculations of the debt/GDP ratio, maintaining market confidence will be crucial. Meanwhile, the ruling coalition is accelerating discussions on increasing defense spending from FY27 onward, and some within an LDP parliamentary group appear to believe that most of the funding can be covered by future tax revenue gains (Nikkei, 28 May).

Decomposing yield movements since last Friday into risk neutral yield (the average of expected future policy rates) and term premium, we see that the latter fell across the curve on expectations for an end to the US-Iran conflict (Figure 2).

Pension fund rebalancing is another focus. Figure 3 shows asset price changes since the start of the month. With domestic and overseas equities posting substantial gains during the week,

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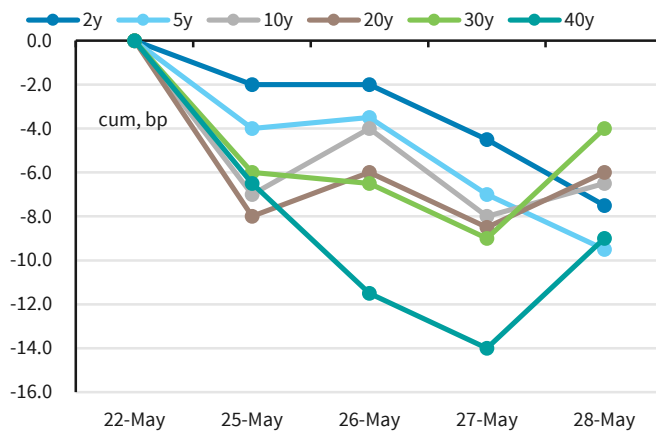
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rebalancing demand into domestic bonds – the only major asset class to have turned lower – appears likely to strengthen on a relative basis.

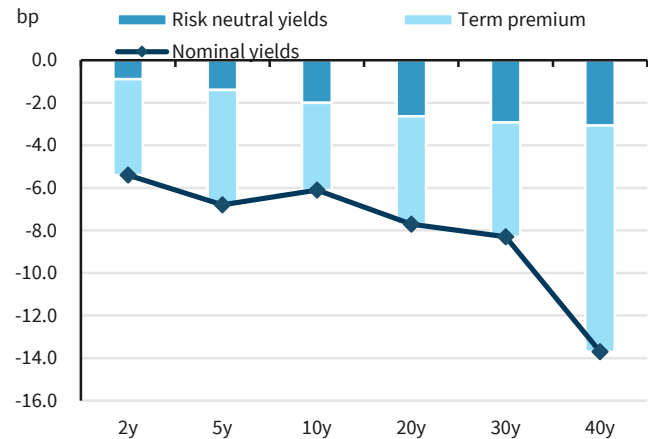
In assessing short-term drivers of JGB yield fluctuations, the relationship with price changes in other assets is also important. [Figure 4](#) decomposes one week of JGB yield changes since last Wednesday into contributions from other asset-price moves such as FX and overseas rates. From last week through this Wednesday, even as yields rose on a weekly basis, overseas rates and domestic factors (residual) contributed to the increase in yen rates.

FIGURE 1. This week's JGB market



Source: Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. Decomposition of yield changes (term premium and risk-neutral yields)

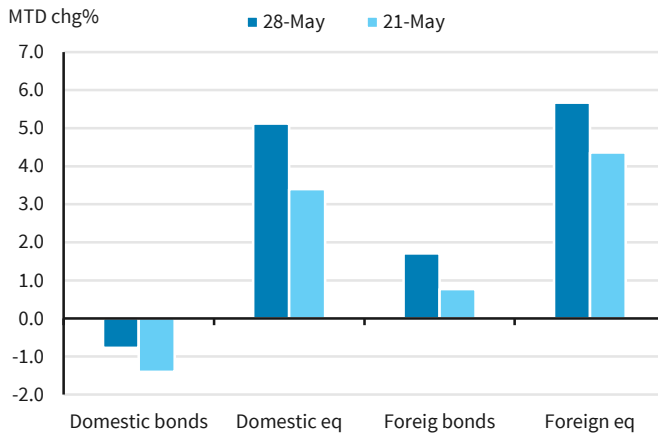


Source: Barclays Research (see [Term premia dominance in superlongs](#))

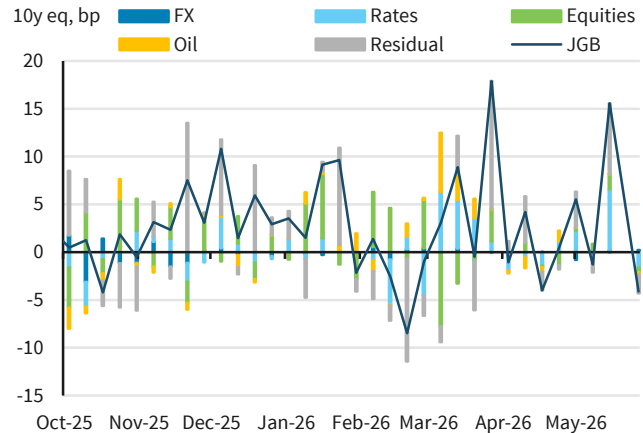
Week ahead

The week ahead brings a 10y JGB auction on the 2nd, then a speech by BoJ Governor Ueda on the 3rd. We have long analyzed that the inflation risk premium, which reflects uncertainty around future inflation, has been a key driver of higher term premiums in the long and superlong sectors. The 10y JGB term premium, which surged last week on headlines related to supplementary budget compilation, has declined this week amid expectations for a US-Iran deal, suggesting some easing in the inflation risk premium. That said, reports from discussions at the Japan Growth Strategy Headquarters – such as the proposal to issue bridging JGBs to finance growth and crisis-management investment and to consider a separate multi-year funding framework (Nikkei, May 28) – suggest that the risk of higher term premiums driven by fiscal headlines is likely to persist. Moreover, with uncertainty rising over the prospects for an early US-Iran agreement, upward pressure on term premiums stemming from potential supply shocks also cannot be ruled out. The 10y auction on the 2nd will therefore serve as a key test of how investors are assessing these risks.

Governor Ueda's speech on the 3rd will also be a focus in grasping the BoJ's communication regarding this inflation risk premium. Deputy Governor Himino's comment on the 26th that "rising inflation concerns are pushing up long-term interest rates" (Nikkei, May 26) suggests that the BoJ likely recognizes that the inflation risk premium is contributing to higher long-end yields. While any remarks related to a potential rate hike at the BoJ's June meeting will naturally be one focal point, communication regarding longer-term inflation risks will also garner attention as a driver of long and superlong yield movements.

FIGURE 3. Asset price changes

Source: Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. Decomposition of JGB yield changes over week since last Wednesday into contributions from other asset price moves

Note: 10y equivalents based on DV01 for each maturity.

Source: MoF, Bloomberg, Barclays Research (see [Decomposition of JGB drivers using the yen-rates FFV model](#))

Recommendations

We recommend: 1) 1y1y/5y5y USDJPY xccy basis flatteners¹ in anticipation of USDJPY xccy basis receiving demand stemming from the US-Japan investment deal; 2) paying 1y1y EURJPY xccy basis as a carry trade²; 3) 2y2y 1x2 payer spread to position for gradual BoJ rate hikes³; and 4) a JGB ASW 10y/30y box⁴, reflecting distortions in the JGB ASW curve.

May Japanese pension rebalancing estimate

This section is an extract from [Japan Flow Update: May Japanese pension rebalancing estimate](#), 25 May 2026. Please refer to the original publication for details.

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¹ [Impact of Takaichi economic policies on JGB term premium](#), 23 October 2025.

² [Xccy and Money Markets: H2 25 market outlook](#), 16 July 2025.

³ [Interest Rate Derivatives: Payer spread for carry amid stabilizing risk premia](#), 3 March 2026.

⁴ [Geopolitics-driven yen rates market](#), 6 March.

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